

Planting in containers

When choosing a container, look at the range of different materials and designs available to find those that suit both your garden style and the types of plants you plan to grow.

In late spring, when all frosts have passed, plant your summer bedding outside in containers, window boxes, and hanging baskets. The method for planting containers and window boxes differs slightly from that of hanging baskets (see below) and they require watering daily. If you have less time to spend watering and feeding, opt for pots of drought-tolerant shrubs, such as hebes, lavenders, and phormiums, or rock plants, like sedums and houseleeks (*Sempervivum*).

Trees and large shrubs in containers add height and stature to a design. Those suitable for growing in pots include boxwood (*Buxus*), many dwarf conifers, *Fatsia japonica*, *Hydrangea serrata*, and choisyas. These will need to be watered regularly in dry spells. In spring, remove the top few inches of potting mix and replace with fresh, together with some all-purpose controlled-release fertilizer.

Choosing pot sizes

When making your container selections, choose pots of several different sizes for a traditional grouping, or opt for a series of pots of the same size and line them up for a contemporary look.

The size of your pots will affect the amount of maintenance they require. Tiny pots dry out quickly, and need watering on a daily basis in summer, unless you plant them with drought-tolerant rock plants. Larger pots hold more potting mix and

therefore more moisture and nutrients, reducing the need for such frequent watering and feeding.

Material options

The material a container is made from affects both the price and the maintenance needs of the plants. Clay is a beautiful natural material, but because it is porous, it dries out more rapidly than synthetic materials or natural stone. Choose glazed clay or plastic if you want colorful pots.



Terra-cotta elegance

Natural and the perfect foil for a shrub, such as a hebe, terracotta is porous and dries out quickly. To prevent moisture loss, line with bubble wrap before planting.

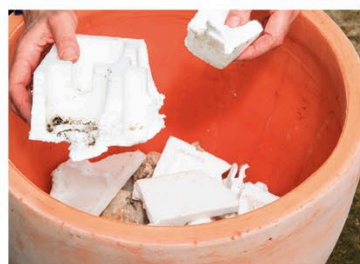


Size matters

Choose a pot size that balances your chosen plants. Opt for a tall, slim container for a fountain of foliage, or a small, wide pot for a rounded shrub or planting group.

PLANTING A SUMMER CONTAINER

You can create exciting displays in containers and window boxes with easy summer flowers. Some grow quickly from seed, or you can buy plug plants via mail order or larger bedding plants from the garden center. When combining plants, try to balance the shapes, colors, and textures. This example includes red dahlias, French marigolds, and yellow bidens.



1 Add drainage material

Place a layer of broken clay pot pieces in the base of the pot to help ensure good drainage. For larger pots, you can reduce the amount of potting mix required and the weight of the container by filling the bottom third with pieces of polystyrene.



2 Plant the container

Fill the container to about 2in (5cm) from the rim with all-purpose potting mix. Work in some slow-release fertilizer granules. Water the plants about 30 minutes before planting. Tip them from their pots or trays and arrange on the soil surface.



Final effects

Plant the tallest plants at the back or in the middle of the container, and fill in around them with shorter or trailing types. Water the plants well, and continue to water regularly. To extend the flowering period, remove the faded blooms with pruning shears at frequent intervals throughout summer.

PLANTING A HANGING BASKET

Globes of flowers and foliage lend an exotic touch to patios and seating areas throughout summer. Plant a large hanging basket and hang it at about head height where you can see the colors and textures at close quarters. Hanging baskets filled with ivy, small evergreens, violas, and early bulbs also add a splash of color in fall and winter.



1 Preparing the basket

Line the basket and add a circle of plastic to the bottom to create a water reservoir. Top with a layer of potting mix. Cut crosses around the sides of the liner. Protect the trailing plants with some plastic and thread them through the crosses, as shown.



2 Planting the top

Cover the roots of the trailing plants with more potting mix, and then start planting the top of the basket. Work from the center out, with the tallest plants (such as verbenas) in the middle, with compact bedding and trailing types around the edges.



Finishing touches

Fill in around the plants with potting mix and work in some slow-release fertilizer granules. Water well and add a layer of gravel over the soil to help retain moisture. Water the basket daily, even if it has rained, and deadhead regularly to extend the flower display throughout the summer.